WEB EXCLUSIVE
India's growth dreams need a reality check
— Deepanshu Mohan
Log on to www.indianexpress.com

WORDLY WISE
When the rich wage war, it's the poor who die.
— Jean-Paul Sartre

The Indian EXPRESS
~ FOUNDED BY ~
RAMNATH GOENKA
IN 1932

BECAUSE THE TRUTH INVOLVES US ALL

Moscow-Kyiv to Delhi, connect the dots

INDIA HAS recently been in the thick of diplomatic efforts to end the war between Russia and Ukraine. A series of high-level engagements has taken place— External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar's meeting with Russian President Vladimir Putin, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's talks with Putin at the SCO summit, where he urged an end to the war "for humanity's sake", and Jaishankar's trip to Kyiv, where President Volodymyr Zelenskyy thanked India for its "commitment to ending this unjust war". A more proactive role for India in the push for peace is welcome. New Delhi should now build on this momentum and use its access to both Moscow and Kyiv to press harder for a negotiated settlement at a time when the US is caught up in the competing demands of the conflicts in Ukraine and West Asia.

Washington and Moscow remain in contact even as the fighting continues with their support. US President Donald Trump's top negotiators met Putin over the weekend. More significantly, CIA Director John Ratcliffe made a secret trip to Moscow two weeks ago. The last known visit to Russia by someone holding that office was nearly five years ago, to warn the Kremlin that the US was aware of its plans to invade Ukraine — a deterrence effort that ultimately failed. Ratcliffe's objective, reportedly, was to convince the Kremlin to cut a deal. The diplomatic pursuit, however, is yet to alter the strategic reality: The US provides Ukraine with intelligence to strike targets inside Russia, while Russia is doing the same for Iran in the Gulf. For all the talk of a reset since the Trump-Putin summit at Anchorage more than a year ago, the two countries remain on opposing sides of two active conflicts.

Neither Ukraine nor Russia is willing to back down in the face of escalation. Russia has intensified its drone and missile strikes on Ukraine, while Ukraine has relentlessly targeted Russian energy infrastructure. The disruption has been severe enough for Moscow to turn to India for petrol imports, while restrictions on fuel sales have been imposed across the country. Across Europe, a series of suspected acts of sabotage are being investigated for possible links to Russia. Any loss of life on European soil could increase the risk of the war spilling further into the continent. The imperative, therefore, is to bring Moscow and Kyiv back to the table and establish, first, a basis for a ceasefire. The protection of energy and civilian infrastructure, as well as commercial shipping lanes in the Black Sea, could be among the first steps. New Delhi should use the upcoming BRICS summit, with Putin and Chinese President Xi Jinping expected to attend, to push for a collective call for such confidence-building measures.

Diabetes care must widen focus, adapt to risks

TYPE 2 diabetes is routinely treated as a blood-sugar disease, managed through monitoring glucose, weight, blood pressure and cholesterol. A new study published in *PLOS Medicine* suggests that this approach misses an important aspect: The disease does not follow quite the same path in men and women. Researchers followed nearly 30,000 people diagnosed with Type 2 diabetes in England between 2010 and 2020 and found that men were more likely to develop cardiovascular disease and end-stage kidney disease, and that they generally reached such complications earlier. Women, meanwhile, were likelier to develop anxiety, depression and other mental-health conditions. Hypertension was the most common complication for both sexes and across all age groups. While part of the gap in mental-health diagnoses could reflect differences in how readily men and women seek care, the study exposes the limits of treating a varied disease with a standard template.

For India, which carries one of the world's heaviest diabetes burdens — more than 101 million Indians live with diabetes and a further 136 million with prediabetes — this has strong implications. A 2026 meta-analysis of Indian studies, published in *Diabetology and Metabolic Syndrome*, found that 38 per cent people with Type 2 diabetes show signs of depression. Another pooled analysis in the *Journal of Diabetes and Metabolic Disorders* published earlier this year estimates those affected by anxiety at roughly three in 10. These suggest that a large number of diabetes patients in the country are carrying an unaddressed mental burden alongside a physical one.

These findings make a strong case for broadening diabetes care beyond its traditional focus on physical risk factors. Treatment should pay closer attention to individual patients, irrespective of their sex, recognising that age, family history, lifestyle, duration of diabetes and access to healthcare have critical impact on outcomes. Primary-care doctors and diabetes clinics should be equipped to recognise mental-health needs and conduct simple screening for anxiety and depression, referring to specialists when necessary. At the same time, greater attention should be paid to regular cardiovascular and kidney assessment in men, without assuming that women are protected from these complications or that men are immune to psychological distress. As the country's diabetes burden continues to grow, treating the condition as something that affects the mind as well as the body could mark a meaningful shift towards more effective care.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



Lost and found: An 'A' for India's long game



N K SINGH

FOR DECADES, our unrealised quest was to be an "A"-rated sovereign. This eluded us. Many of us who interacted with rating agencies remained perplexed by their opaque methodology. The predilections and biases successively penalised fast-growing emerging markets even with low external debt and sound macroeconomic frameworks. The duality of standards, often based on territorial location of economic activity, influenced the outcomes.

Finally, on September 2, came a breakthrough. The Japan Credit Rating Agency upgraded India's long-term sovereign rating, from BBB+ to A-, and the country ceiling was raised to A.

The last time India held an A-grade was January 1988, when Moody's assigned us the A2 rating. However, our borrowing fuelled growth of the 1980s meant the A-grade did not last. The central government's fiscal deficit reached 9.1 per cent of GDP and the current account deficit rose to 3.1 per cent of GDP in FY 1989-90. The continued political instability of three prime ministers in as many years inevitably delayed reforms. The prospect of fiscal rectitude was not in sight. Thereafter came the First Gulf War, rising oil prices and India's Balance of Payment crisis.

By October 1990, India was downgraded to Baa1. By mid-1991, our reserves barely covered a few weeks of imports and investor psychology was weak. We were further downgraded to non-investment grade. Notwithstanding credible progress through successive governments thereon, efforts to secure the A-grade were not accepted. Thirty-six years passed by since the A-grade was lost.

Sovereign credit ratings are independent assessments of a country's creditworthiness by leading global rating agencies. They range from the coveted AAA to "junk" status, with BB+ and below classified as non-investment grade (junk). It is a probability of default, expressed as a letter grade.

Under Basel III regulations, they remain embedded in the capital rules of banks. A sovereign upgrade potentially lowers the "risk weights" or the capital that banks must hold against government debt. Lower risk weights mean stronger demand for sovereign bonds and cheaper funding. A downgrade would mean the opposite.

The industry itself dates to 1909, when John Moody began grading American railroad bonds, with sovereign ratings following in the 1920s. The agencies that dominate: S&P Global, Moody's, Fitch, Japan Credit Rating Agency, R&I of Japan and Morningstar DBRS. Agencies assess institutional strength and governance, economic structure and growth. External accounts and reserve adequacy, the fiscal position, the foreclosure of revenue for servicing debt and debt path, and monetary flexibility come into play. This framework can, however, be opaque with judgement. A territorial divide emerges between advanced economies and the Global South.

Yet they remain important because they influence boardroom decisions of investors. Curiously, even international institutions like the World Bank (obsessed with retaining their AAA rating) and some sovereign governments are also conscious of the rating they secure.

The Japan Credit Rating Agency itself cites "high growth rate of around 7 per cent, supported by robust private consumption and public investment", "supported by personal income-tax cuts and reductions of GST rates, with the economy growing 7.7 per cent in real GDP terms" and "the banking sector's gross nonperforming loan ratio [which] declined to 1.8 per cent... supported by the establishment of Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, capital injections by the government". Almost every item on that list is structural rather than cyclical.

> We must also recognise that their decision comes at a time notwithstanding the odds and uncertainties of tariff frictions, tensions in West Asia and elevated oil prices

We must also recognise that their decision comes at a time notwithstanding the odds and uncertainties of tariff frictions, tensions in West Asia and elevated oil prices. These fears have been quashed by India's macroeconomic and political stability, and continuing structural reforms. This paradigm shift, more than any single number, is what the A- represents.

It is symbolic of the confidence in India's long-term growth prospects. This increases the pressure and "nudge" effect on other rating agencies: S&P Global, Moody's and Fitch, which hold India at BBB, Baa3 and BBB-, respectively. Generally, agencies are wary of being conspicuous outliers.

The upgrade arrived days after the first quarter estimates for 2026-27. India recorded real GDP growth of 7.8 per cent, nominal growth of 10.3 per cent, real GVA growth of 8.2 per cent and gross fixed capital formation growing 11.9 per cent. Some critics have wrongly suggested the number is contrived but this charge does not survive basic scrutiny. GDP series are revised the world over as the structure of an economy changes and more granular data become available. India has revised its series many a times: 1948–49, 1960–61, 1970–71, 1980–81, 1993–94, 1999–2000, 2004–05, 2011–12, and 2022–23.

More importantly, this revision addresses what IMF's assessments had flagged in our old GDP series. In particular, the outdated base year and its reliance on wholesale rather than producer prices. The new series introduces Output Producer Price Index, adopts double deflation across sectors, including manufacturing, and aligns us closer to the global System of National Accounts (SNA) 2008. MOSPI has stated clearly that the revisions do "not represent a downward revision made to make the current year's growth appear higher". The improved implicit deflator now has "more than 300 individual price deflators" reflecting its granularity.

There are three reasons why this moment is significant. First, an unsolicited upgrade to the A-grade is an external verdict, not a negotiated one. Second, it validates institutions built through Centre-state consensus, the GST Council foremost among them, whose pooled sovereignty has no true parallel elsewhere. Third, it should translate into lower risk premia in corporate boardrooms. This is where foreign direct investment decisions are actually taken, and augurs well for inward capital flows.

When the crisis in the Straits broke out, many thought India's Goldilocks economy was coming to an end. Despite everything that seemed to be going wrong, the economy remains just right. Growth near 8 per cent, inflation within the band, banks at their cleanest in a generation, and capital arriving rather than departing.

Keynes once cautioned against becoming the prisoners of our own habitual ideas. Rating committees are unusually prone to that particular imprisonment. The reforms of 1991 were once dismissed as compulsion rather than conviction. History has been unkind to that verdict. Thirty-six years on, India is back where it belongs.

The writer is former chairman, 15th Finance Commission

Two countries and a shared river: Mistrust is not inevitable



DIBYESH ANAND

INDIA'S MOST important rivers rise in a region it cannot see into, controlled by China, which treats the data about them as an asset to switch on and off. The Brahmaputra rises as the Yarlung Tsangpo in Tibet, entering Arunachal as the Siang; the Sutlej and Indus rise there too. What India knows of them at their source, it knows because Beijing chooses to tell it.

India and China have no water treaty — only two flood-season memorandums, on the Brahmaputra (2002) and the Sutlej (2005), for which India pays roughly a crore a year, plus a consultative mechanism that meets when relations allow. The edifice is deliberately flimsy: China shares data, but on its own terms and its own reading of what sovereignty permits. Both India and China, tellingly, stand outside the 1997 UN Watercourses Convention, which would oblige upstream states to give prior notice and not harm those below. China voted against it; India abstained. A non-binding memorandum can be suspended without breach. In 2017, during the standoff at Doklam, China stopped sharing Brahmaputra data, blaming damaged collection sites, even as that summer's floods killed scores in Assam. It resumed once relations thawed, then dried up after the 2020 Galwan clash; the memorandum lapsed in June 2025. Flood prediction data is not a neutral public good but a lever — released when ties are warm, withdrawn when they are not.

Beijing tells a different story. It blames the stoppages on technical faults, calls the dam "fully within China's sovereignty" and promises it will "prevent and mitigate disasters". Some of that may be true. But I recall a Chinese scholar's remark on a state-controlled visit to Tibet in a delegation I joined: He pointed at a river and made a snide comment, "That is a river that flows into India, and we can stop it any time we want." Every reassurance shares one flaw: Those meant to be reassured cannot verify it, because the region is sealed.

If the flood is the symptom, the dam is the escalation. In July 2025, China broke ground on the Medog project at the Great Bend of the Yarlung Tsangpo just before the river turns towards Arunachal. At 60 GW, it will be the world's largest hydropower project, in one of the planet's most seismically violent zones — the same tectonic seam that produces the outburst floods now hitting the border. Arunachal's chief minister has called it an "existential threat" to Siang valley; Bangladesh, at the river's end, sought details in early 2026 and got none.

> India's most important rivers rise in a region controlled by China, which treats the data about them as an asset to switch on and off

The plateau is so opaque because of how China governs Tibet — as a colonised space, held through near-total domination. India, which hosts the Dalai Lama and the largest Tibetan exile community, is viewed with particular suspicion. Yet this is no morality tale of Chinese secrecy against Indian virtue. India has been complicit in its own exposure: Successive governments have settled for the paid-data memorandum and not pushed for the binding, basin-wide architecture that would make information a right, not a favour. Nor is India only a victim. It is an upstream withholder too — sharing thinly with Bangladesh and, this year, suspending the Indus Waters Treaty with Pakistan after the Pahalgam terror attack. The logic it faces on the Brahmaputra is the logic it practises on the Indus.

None of this is inevitable. On the Senegal River, four of the world's poorest African countries jointly own their dams as "common and indivisible property", sustaining it even through a war between two members. If states this impoverished and mistrustful can pool sovereignty over a river, China's refusal is a choice, not a constraint — as its absence from the Mekong Commission its neighbours built confirms.

India's water future is tied to a plateau it can neither see into nor shape, held by a mistrustful neighbour across a hot border. The question is not whether India can force China to open up, which it cannot, but whether it will build the institutions that make hazard information a shared necessity, not a bargaining chip. The two must also decide whether a shared river is a common lifeline or a weapon held in reserve.

The writer is professor of International Relations, University of Westminster, London

Gloria Steinem taught us that hardest battles are fought inside



AMRITA NANDY

MOST OF US are indifferent and even averse to feminism, but stay rather curious about feminists. We may not notice this contradiction, let alone admit it, perhaps because we stay engrossed in scrutinising, stereotyping and (most of all) bashing feminism and feminists, as if dissidents deserve harsher judgement. So when a famous feminist passes on, there is a tsunami of judgement. And since no life can be only glorious, even if one is named Gloria (Steinem), criticisms are bound to be recounted. She was roasted, at times understandably, for her stance on sex work, the supposed links with the CIA, etc.

Monochrome or nuanced, the ledger of a human life can often miss a vital pivot: Aiming the lens on our own judgement-making. Should it spotlight errors or take a long view to balance judgement? These questions could be useful because to be a feminist – publicly — is to have a dog whistle being constantly blown by the moral police. To make a case about such policing, I deploy Steinem as a placeholder. This piece is not about her but about us *vis-à-vis* feminists and feminism. Her *Revolution from Within* (1992) proposed that along with rights-based, social justice work, women dig within to join the dots between inner oppression and outer regimes, then unshackle themselves inwardly and pull up self-esteem. She cited the Upanishads to state that the self was one among the many sites to fight that most stubborn of adversaries, patriarchy. Activism, much like meaningful living, gains when self-awareness aligns with our social radar. The book was a bestseller, but Steinem got flak from her own tribe for downgrading to "self-help", for having gone "soft", and losing her way.

Why is talking openly of one's inner turmoil and personal trauma difficult, if not unacceptable? There seems to be a persistent concern: It is self-indulgent weakness, and distracts us from our grail — outer, structural, and systemic barriers. Inner resilience is indeed a prized asset, but why invisibilise our authentic truths? Because are the (hardest) battles actually not fought inside? And does valorising strength not de-humanise us, like it does for men and masculinity? Perhaps we can use that strength to hold our opinions with less force, to be less harsh when we, our friends, disappoint? Maybe it can make feminism kinder?

On the other hand, feminist bashers burrow into the personal lives of feminists to discredit them and their worldview. Steinem's fulsome life of friendships, love, and marriage seemed like a contradiction to their (mis)understanding of feminism as a men-hating, anti-marriage project. Her response: "I did not change, marriage changed. We spent 30 years in the US changing marriage laws. If I had married when I was supposed to... I would have lost my name, ... many of my civil rights. That is not true anymore. It is possible to make an equal marriage".

> Steinem's fulsome life of friendships, love, and marriage seemed like a contradiction to their (mis)understanding of feminism as a men-hating, anti-marriage project

Since stereotypes swamp popular notions of feminism, judgements by and for feminists deserve care. To be a non-conforming woman imposes greater accountability, more self-reliance, a constant eye at one's privileges, victimhood, and contradictions. Feminism is an ongoing practice, a cultivation of positions and temperament so we could disagree and still be agreeable.

Nandy is author of Occupy the Spiritual, Reimagine the Social

40 YEARS AGO

September 7, 1986


INDIAN EXPRESS
Bungling by Pakistan: PM
'Inept handling led to deaths'

Pan Am aircraft hijack

THE PRIME Minister Rajiv Gandhi blamed the Pakistani authorities for their ham-handed action in dealing with the hijackers who had seized the Pan Am aircraft, in which 16 people were killed and several were injured (according to the latest reports). The Prime Minister said it was very difficult for him to say who was responsible for the hijacking incident. But he noted that the hijackers were reportedly speaking Urdu — "a language which is spoken only in the subcontinent and not outside."

Reagan praises Islamabad

PAKISTAN AUTHORITIES were blamed by Pan American airline for the security lapses which enabled terrorists to seize its jumbo jet at Karachi airport. Pan Am's chief operating officer told a press conference in New York that Pakistani officials were responsible for allowing the airport perimeter to be "penetrated by terrorists". There was no failure on the part of the airline. However, President Reagan praised the Pakistani government for acting "boldly and decisively to bring this nightmare to an end". The US government applauds Islamabad's "exemplary resolve in the handling of this incident", he said.

Flight purser killed

NEERJA MISHRA, a senior Indian flight purser on the hijacked Pan Am jumbo, was killed by terrorists before Pakistani commandos could enter the aircraft, according to information received in Bombay. Mishra was rushed to Karachi's Jinnah hospital, where she was declared dead. Her body is being flown to Bombay. Mishra was to celebrate her 23rd birthday on September 7.